

CLAT Express - August 2026: Study Notes

Chapters, topics and sub-topics with key facts, memory aids and mind-map outlines.

International Relations and News

Ceuta Migration Crisis and International Refugee Frameworks

Refugee, Asylum Seeker and Migrant

The booklet distinguishes three categories of people on the move: refugees, asylum seekers and migrants. Each category differs in why the person moves, what protection applies, and which law governs the person's stay.

- Refugee: forced to flee due to persecution or conflict.
- Refugee is protected under the 1951 Refugee Convention.
- Refugees cannot be forcibly returned (non-refoulement).
- Asylum seeker: a person seeking recognition as a refugee.
- Asylum seeker is awaiting a decision on refugee status.
- Asylum seeker receives temporary protection during the application.
- Migrant: moves mainly for work, education or better opportunities.
- Migrant may migrate legally or irregularly.
- Migrant is governed mainly by domestic immigration laws.

Mind-map outline

Three categories of people on the move

- Refugee
 - Forced to flee persecution or conflict
 - Protected under 1951 Refugee Convention
 - Cannot be forcibly returned
- Asylum seeker
 - Seeks recognition as a refugee
 - Awaiting decision on refugee status
 - Receives temporary protection
- Migrant
 - Moves for work, education or opportunity
 - May migrate legally or irregularly
 - Governed by domestic immigration laws

Ceuta: Location and Strategic Importance

Ceuta is an Autonomous City of Spain on the northern coast of Africa, next to Morocco. Its position at the eastern entrance of the Strait of Gibraltar makes it one of the shortest routes into European territory from Africa. Together with Melilla, it forms one of the EU's two land borders with Africa.

- Ceuta's status is Autonomous City of Spain.
- Ceuta lies on the northern coast of Africa.
- Ceuta's neighbouring country is Morocco.
- Ceuta's coast faces the Mediterranean Sea.
- Ceuta is at the eastern entrance of the Strait of Gibraltar.
- Ceuta lies at the junction of the Atlantic Ocean and Mediterranean Sea.
- Ceuta represents one of the shortest routes into European territory from Africa.
- Ceuta and Melilla together form one of the EU's two land borders with Africa.
- Ceuta and Melilla are Spanish exclaves separated from Morocco by fortified border fences, which are often breached by immigrants.

Mnemonic - Key features of Ceuta: SGT: Short Gibraltar Trip

S = One of the shortest routes into European territory from Africa; G = Located at the eastern entrance of the Strait of Gibraltar; T = Forms one of the EU's two land borders with Africa, along with Melilla

Mind-map outline

Ceuta: location and strategic importance

- Status and location

- Autonomous City of Spain
- Northern coast of Africa
- Neighbouring country: Morocco
- Sea and strait
 - Mediterranean Sea coast
 - Eastern entrance of Strait of Gibraltar
 - Junction of Atlantic and Mediterranean
- Borders and routes
 - One of EU's two land borders with Africa
 - Shortest route into European territory
 - Fences often breached by immigrants

Spanish Territories and the Western Sahara Link

Ceuta, Melilla and Plazas de Soberania are Spanish territories associated with the North African mainland. Morocco disputes their status, and the migration issue is closely linked to the Western Sahara dispute. Changes in Spain's relations with Morocco and Algeria have repeatedly affected migration flows through Ceuta.

- Spanish territories associated with the North African mainland: Ceuta, Melilla and Plazas de Soberania.
- Spain exercises sovereignty over these territories.
- Morocco disputes their status and has sought their return since gaining independence in 1956.
- Western Sahara, a former Spanish colony, was annexed by Morocco in 1975.
- The Polisario Front declared the Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic (SADR) in 1976.
- The Polisario Front demands self-determination for the Sahrawi people.
- Algeria supports the Polisario Front, while Morocco proposes autonomy under its sovereignty.
- Changes in Spain's relations with Morocco and Algeria have repeatedly influenced migration flows through Ceuta.

Mind-map outline

Spanish territories and Western Sahara

- Spanish territories
 - Ceuta, Melilla, Plazas de Soberania
 - Spain exercises sovereignty
 - Morocco disputes status since 1956
- Western Sahara
 - Former Spanish colony
 - Annexed by Morocco in 1975
 - Polisario Front declared SADR in 1976
- Link to migration
 - Migration linked to Western Sahara dispute
 - Algeria supports Polisario Front
 - Spain-Morocco-Algeria ties shape flows

International Frameworks on Refugees and Trafficking

Several international instruments govern refugees and human trafficking. The 1951 Refugee Convention and its 1967 Protocol set out refugee protection, while the Palermo instruments of 2000 target organised crime and trafficking. Other treaties and forums address refugee children, host countries and civil and political rights.

- The UN Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (Palermo Convention, 2000) combats transnational organised crime through international cooperation.
- The Palermo Protocol (2000) aims to prevent, suppress and punish trafficking in persons, especially women and children.
- The 1951 Refugee Convention defines a refugee as one fleeing persecution.
- The 1951 Convention specifies certain categories, such as war criminals, who do not qualify for refugee status.
- The 1967 Protocol expanded refugee protection beyond Europe, removing geographic and time limits.

- The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (1966) safeguards individuals from torture or inhuman treatment upon return.
- The Global Compact on Refugees (2018) offers a framework to support refugees and host countries.
- The Convention on the Rights of the Child (1989) advocates for refugee children's welfare.
- The Global Refugee Forum is held every four years.

Mind-map outline

International frameworks on refugees and trafficking

- Refugee law
 - 1951 Refugee Convention
 - 1967 Protocol removed geographic and time limits
 - ICCPR (1966): no torture upon return
- Trafficking and crime
 - Palermo Convention (2000): organised crime
 - Palermo Protocol (2000): trafficking in persons
- Other instruments
 - Global Compact on Refugees (2018)
 - Convention on Rights of the Child (1989)
 - Global Refugee Forum every four years

UNHCR and India's Approach to Refugees

The UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) was formed in 1950 as successor to the International Refugee Organization, and its office originated in 1921 under the League of Nations. India is not a signatory to the 1951 Convention or the 1967 Protocol, and it regulates undocumented foreigners under domestic Acts.

- UNHCR was formed on 14 December 1950.
- UNHCR succeeded the International Refugee Organization (1946).
- The office of High Commissioner for Refugees originated in 1921 under the League of Nations, led by Fridtjof Nansen.
- UNHCR's headquarters are in Geneva, Switzerland.
- UNHCR received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1954 and 1981.
- The UNHCR Nansen Refugee Award was established in 1954 and is named after Fridtjof Nansen.
- The Nansen Award honours exceptional service to refugees, displaced or stateless people annually.
- India is not a signatory to the 1951 Refugee Convention or the 1967 Protocol.
- All undocumented foreigners in India are regulated under the Foreigners Act (1946), the Registration of Foreigners Act (1939), the Passport (Entry into India) Act (1920) and the Citizenship Act (1955).

Mind-map outline

UNHCR and India's approach

- UNHCR
 - Formed 14 December 1950
 - Successor to International Refugee Organization
 - Headquarters in Geneva
- Honours
 - Nobel Peace Prize 1954 and 1981
 - Nansen Refugee Award since 1954
 - World Refugee Day: June 20
- India
 - Not a signatory to 1951 Convention
 - Foreigners Act, 1946
 - Citizenship Act, 1955

China's Antelope Reef Base in the South China Sea

Location and Geography of the South China Sea

The South China Sea is an arm of the Western Pacific Ocean that borders the South-East Asian mainland. It is bordered by seven countries and connects with the East China Sea and the Philippine Sea through two straits. Together with the East China Sea, it forms what is termed the China Sea.

- Arm of the Western Pacific Ocean that borders South-East Asian mainland
- Bordered by Brunei, China, Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Taiwan and Vietnam
- Taiwan Strait connects it with the East China Sea
- Luzon Strait connects it with the Philippine Sea
- South China Sea and East China Sea together form the China Sea
- Lies in a heavily trafficked maritime zone used for a large portion of global trade

Mind-map outline

South China Sea location

- Part of the Western Pacific
 - Arm of Western Pacific Ocean
 - Borders South-East Asian mainland
- Bordering countries
 - Brunei, China, Indonesia, Malaysia
 - Philippines, Taiwan, Vietnam
- Connections
 - Taiwan Strait to East China Sea
 - Luzon Strait to Philippine Sea

Importance of the South China Sea

The sea holds large estimated reserves of oil and natural gas and has rich fishing grounds. It is also a major trade corridor, with UNCTAD estimating that over a fifth of global trade passes through it. Nearly one-third of the world's shipping trade moves through this waterway each year.

- Estimated 11 billion barrels of oil in deposits under the sea (US EIA)
- Estimated 190 trillion cubic feet of natural gas in deposits (US EIA)
- Rich fishing grounds with an estimated 12% of the world's fisheries
- More than half of the world's fishing vessels operate in this area
- Over 21% of global trade, amounting to \$3.37 trillion (UNCTAD)
- Nearly one-third of the world's shipping trade passes through annually

Mind-map outline

Importance of the South China Sea

- Energy
 - 11 billion barrels of oil
 - 190 trillion cubic feet of gas
- Fisheries
 - About 12% of world fisheries
 - Over half of world fishing vessels
- Trade and shipping
 - Over 21% of global trade
 - Nearly one-third of world shipping

Antelope Reef Development and Strategic Role

China has completed the first phase of development at Antelope Reef, which lies in the disputed Paracel Islands. The project reportedly includes an artificial island of nearly 6 km and a 680-metre wharf linked to a deep-water harbour. China says the development serves civilian purposes, but the facility could also strengthen its military infrastructure and protect its submarines.

- China completed the 1st phase of development at Antelope Reef
- Antelope Reef lies in the disputed Paracel Islands
- China has reclaimed an artificial island spanning nearly 6 km
- Reported infrastructure includes a helicopter pad
- A 680-metre wharf connected to a deep-water harbour
- Nearly 3 km straight coastline potentially suitable for an airstrip or runway

- Could become a protected maritime 'Bastion' for nuclear-powered ballistic-missile submarines
- Could give greater protection from surveillance by the US and Vietnam

Mnemonic - Antelope Reef infrastructure: Hens Hop Wobble Along

Hens = Helicopter pad; Hop = Deep-water harbour; Wobble = 680-metre wharf; Along = Nearly 3 km straight coastline potentially suitable for an airstrip or runway

Mind-map outline

Antelope Reef development

- Infrastructure
 - Artificial island of nearly 6 km
 - 680 m wharf to deep-water harbour
 - Helicopter pad
 - Nearly 3 km coastline for airstrip
- Stated purpose
 - Civilian purposes
 - Weather monitoring and scientific research
- Strategic role
 - Bastion for nuclear-powered submarines
 - Protection from US and Vietnam surveillance

Legal Disputes: Nine-Dash Line, UNCLOS and the PCA

China's claims in the South China Sea are described through the Nine-Dash Line, which began as an 11-dashed line in 1947. UNCLOS came into force in 1994 as a legal framework, but its interpretation in this sea remains fiercely disputed. In 2016 the Permanent Court of Arbitration ruled that China's claims over 90% of the sea were illegitimate, and China rejected the ruling.

- The 11-dashed line was indicated by the Nationalist Kuomintang Government in 1947
- The Nine-Dash Line claims roughly 90% of the 3.5 million sq km area it defines
- The 1951 Treaty of San Francisco forced Imperial Japan to give up conquered territories
- UNCLOS came into force in 1994
- ASEAN and China signed the Declaration on the Code of Conduct in 2002
- PCA was established at The Hague by a convention concluded in 1899
- PCA rulings are binding but the PCA has no powers to enforce them
- 2016 PCA ruling: China's claims over 90% of the sea were illegitimate
- China rejected the ruling and prefers bilateral negotiations

Mnemonic - Key legal dates: Nine-Nine Hague, Nine-Four Law, Oh-Two Code, Sixteen Ruling

Nine-Nine (1899) = Convention concluded at The Hague that established the PCA; Nine-Four (1994) = UNCLOS came into force; Oh-Two (2002) = ASEAN and China signed the Declaration on the Code of Conduct; Sixteen (2016) = PCA ruled China's claims over 90% of the sea illegitimate

Mind-map outline

Legal disputes in the sea

- Nine-Dash Line
 - Began as 11-dashed line in 1947
 - Claims roughly 90% of 3.5 million sq km
- UNCLOS
 - Came into force in 1994
 - Interpretation still disputed
- Permanent Court of Arbitration
 - Established at The Hague in 1899
 - 2016 ruling rejected by China
 - Rulings binding but not enforceable

Island Claims and Implications for India

The Paracel Islands are claimed by China, Taiwan and Vietnam, and China has exercised de facto control since 1974. The Spratly Islands and Scarborough Shoal also have overlapping claims, and a 2012 standoff gave China de facto control over the Scarborough region. For India, regional stability matters because much of its maritime commerce passes through this sea and the Malacca Strait.

- Paracel Islands are claimed by China, Taiwan and Vietnam
- Spratly Islands are claimed by China, Taiwan, Vietnam, Brunei and the Philippines

- Scarborough Shoal is claimed by the Philippines, China and Taiwan
- China has exercised de facto control of the Paracels since 1974
- A 2012 standoff resulted in China gaining de facto control over the Scarborough region
- A significant share of India's maritime commerce passes through the South China Sea and Malacca Strait
- Greater Chinese militarisation could threaten security of Sea Lines of Communication
- Challenges India's traditional role as a Net Security Provider in the Indian Ocean Region

Mind-map outline

Island claims and India

- Paracel Islands
 - Claimed by China, Taiwan, Vietnam
 - Chinese de facto control since 1974
- Scarborough Shoal
 - Claimed by Philippines, China, Taiwan
 - 2012 standoff gave China control
- India
 - Trade through South China Sea and Malacca
 - Net Security Provider role challenged

UNSC Straw Poll for Next UN Secretary-General

Selection Process and Nominations

The selection begins with a joint communication from the Presidents of the General Assembly and the Security Council, inviting UN Member States to nominate candidates. Candidates typically submit a CV and vision statement, then take part in interactive dialogues with member states. Straw polls then narrow the field before the Council formally recommends a candidate.

- Joint communication from Presidents of UNGA and UNSC starts the process
- 193 UN Member States are invited to nominate candidates
- Candidates generally submit CV, vision statements and relevant information
- Nominees take part in interactive dialogues with Member States
- Straw polls narrow the field before the Council formally recommends a candidate
- Article 97 of UN Charter: General Assembly appoints SG on Council recommendation
- Selection involves 2 formal stages: UNSC recommends, UNGA appoints

Mind-map outline

Selection of UN Secretary-General

- Joint communication from two Presidents
- 193 Member States nominate candidates
- Candidates submit CV and vision
- Interactive dialogues with member states
- Straw polls narrow the field
- UNSC recommends; UNGA appoints

Straw Polls and Permanent Member Signals

Straw polls are informal and confidential voting exercises that assess how acceptable each candidate is to Security Council members. Members indicate Encourage, Discourage or No Opinion. In later rounds the Permanent Members use distinctively coloured ballots, so a Discourage from a Permanent Member signals a likely veto. Rounds continue until a candidate demonstrates sufficient support.

- Straw polls are informal and confidential voting exercises
- Purpose: assess relative acceptability of candidates
- Members indicate one of three positions: Encourage, Discourage, No Opinion
- Encourage means the member supports or favours the candidate
- Permanent Members use distinctively coloured ballots in subsequent rounds
- A Discourage from a Permanent Member effectively signals a veto in a formal vote
- Straw poll rounds continue until a candidate demonstrates sufficient support
- A preferred candidate needs at least 9 of 15 votes and no veto from any Permanent Member

Mnemonic - Straw poll positions: Every Discourage Needs Notice

E = Encourage: member supports or favours the candidate; D = Discourage: member indicates opposition to the candidate; N = No Opinion: member has not taken a position

Mind-map outline

Straw polls

- Informal and confidential
- Assess relative acceptability
- Three positions
 - Encourage: supports candidate
 - Discourage: opposition
 - No Opinion: no position taken
- P5 signals
 - Distinctively coloured ballots
 - P5 Discourage means likely veto
- Continue until sufficient support

Appointment, Term and Regional Rotation

Article 97 provides for appointment by the General Assembly on the Council's recommendation, and appointments have traditionally been made by consensus or acclamation. The Charter sets no fixed term; established practice provides for a 5-year term, conventionally renewable once. Regional rotation is an informal political convention that promotes geographical representation.

- UN Charter does not prescribe a fixed term limit for the Secretary-General
- Established UN practice provides for a 5-year term
- Term is conventionally renewable once, based on practice rather than an explicit Charter provision
- General Assembly can decide by majority vote but appointments are traditionally by consensus or acclamation
- Regional rotation is an informal principle to promote geographical representation
- Five broad regional groupings are involved: African, Asia-Pacific, Eastern European, Latin American and Caribbean, Western European and Other States
- Regional rotation is a political convention, not a legally binding provision

Mnemonic - Term and rotation: Five Years, Renew Once, Regions Rotate

Five = Established UN practice provides for a 5-year term; Once = Term is conventionally renewable once, based on practice; Regions = Regional rotation is an informal principle promoting geographical representation

Mind-map outline

Appointment, term and rotation

- Appointment
 - Article 97: GA appoints on UNSC recommendation
 - Traditionally by consensus or acclamation
- Term
 - No fixed Charter term
 - Practice: 5-year term
 - Conventionally renewable once
- Regional rotation
 - Informal principle for geographical representation
 - Five broad regional groupings
 - Political convention, not legally binding

UNSC Structure and the Veto

The UNSC is one of the six principal organs of the UN and has 15 members, each with one vote. The five Permanent Members hold veto power, so opposition from any one of them blocks a decision regardless of wider support. The booklet argues that the Council still reflects the post-Second World War order rather than the present world.

- UNSC is one of the six principal organs of the UN
- 15 members, and each member has one vote
- Five Permanent Members hold veto power
- Opposition from any one Permanent Member blocks a decision regardless of other support

- A retiring member is not eligible for immediate re-election
- The five Permanent Members gained permanent membership because they won WWII
- The veto system has become a tool to block progress in the UN
- During the Russia-Ukraine conflict, the UNSC was powerless due to Russia's veto

Mind-map outline

UNSC structure and veto

- Membership
 - 15 members, one vote each
 - Retiring member not immediately re-eligible
- Permanent members
 - Five P5 members hold veto
 - Any one P5 opposition blocks
- Criticism
 - Still reflects 1945 world order
 - Veto can block progress
 - Russia's veto left UNSC powerless in Ukraine conflict

National News and Issues

Cauvery Water Dispute

Cauvery River and its basin

The Cauvery is an east-flowing Peninsular River, known as 'Ganga of the South', that rises at Talakaveri in Kodagu, Karnataka. It flows through Karnataka and Tamil Nadu before draining into the Bay of Bengal near Poompuhar. Its drainage basin covers four states and UTs, and its upper and lower basins receive different monsoons.

- Also known as 'Ganga of the South'
- East-flowing Peninsular River
- Origin: Talakaveri, Brahmagiri Hills, Kodagu (Karnataka)
- Flows through Karnataka and Tamil Nadu
- Drains into the Bay of Bengal near Poompuhar
- Drainage basin: Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Puducherry
- Upper Basin receives the Southwest Monsoon
- Lower Basin benefits from the Northeast Monsoon
- Major dams: Krishna Raja Sagara (Karnataka) and Mettur Dam (Tamil Nadu)

Mind-map outline

Cauvery River

- Origin: Talakaveri, Kodagu, Karnataka
- Flows through Karnataka, then Tamil Nadu
- Mouth: Bay of Bengal near Poompuhar
- Major dams
 - Krishna Raja Sagara (Karnataka)
 - Mettur Dam (Tamil Nadu)
- Monsoons
 - Upper basin: Southwest Monsoon
 - Lower basin: Northeast Monsoon

Historical roots and tribunal awards

The dispute has roots in an 1892 agreement between the Madras Presidency and the princely state of Mysore, after which Madras objected to Mysore's irrigation and storage plans. A 1924 agreement allowed Mysore to build a dam at Kannambadi, which led to the Krishnaraja Sagar Dam. After the agreement came up for review following 1974, the matter moved to the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal, constituted in 1990, whose 2007 award and the 2018 Supreme Court judgment fixed the water shares.

- 1892 Agreement between Madras Presidency and Princely State of Mysore
- Madras objected to Mysore's plans to expand irrigation and build storage structures
- 1924 Agreement permitted Mysore to build a dam at Kannambadi village

- The Kannambadi dam led to development of the Krishnaraja Sagar Dam
- 1924 Agreement was intended to operate for 50 years; came up for review after 1974
- Dispute brought under Article 262 and the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956
- Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal (CWDT) constituted in 1990
- CWDT Award 2007: 740 TMC in total
- 2007 Award split: Tamil Nadu 419, Karnataka 270, Kerala 30, Puducherry 7, environment 14 TMC
- Supreme Court Judgment 2018: Karnataka 284.75 TMC, Tamil Nadu 404.25 TMC

Mind-map outline

Historical roots

- 1892: Madras Presidency and Mysore agreement
 - Madras objected to Mysore's plans
- 1924: Kannambadi dam permitted
 - Led to Krishnaraja Sagar Dam
- After 1974: agreement under review
 - Major contention between successor states
- Tribunal era
 - CWDT constituted in 1990
 - 2007 Award: 740 TMC total
 - 2018 SC: Karnataka 284.75, TN 404.25 TMC

Cauvery Water Management Authority

The Cauvery Water Management Authority was established in 2018 under the Cauvery Water Management Scheme, 2018, along with the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee. It is a statutory, quasi-judicial body notified under the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956, and its purpose is to implement the modified CWDT Award upheld by the Supreme Court in 2018. Its composition mixes full-time members, part-time central government members and part-time members from the basin states, with headquarters in New Delhi under the Ministry of Jal Shakti.

- Established in 2018 under the Cauvery Water Management Scheme, 2018
- Set up along with the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee
- Statutory, quasi-judicial body
- Notified under Section 6A of the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956
- Purpose: implement the modified CWDT Award, upheld by the Supreme Court in 2018
- Chairperson appointed by the Central Government for a 5-year term
- 2 full-time members
- 2 part-time Central Government members
- 4 part-time members representing Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Puducherry
- Headquarters: New Delhi (Ministry of Jal Shakti)

Mnemonic - CWMA composition: Full Central States

Full = 2 full-time members on the Authority; Central = 2 part-time Central Government members; States = 4 part-time members for Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Puducherry

Mind-map outline

Cauvery Water Management Authority

- Set up in 2018
 - Under Cauvery Water Management Scheme, 2018
 - Alongside Cauvery Water Regulation Committee
- Legal basis
 - Statutory, quasi-judicial body
 - Section 6A, ISRWD Act, 1956
- Purpose
 - Implement modified CWDT Award
- Composition
 - Chairperson: 5-year term
 - 2 full-time members
 - 2 part-time Central Government members
 - 4 part-time state and UT members
- Headquarters: New Delhi, Ministry of Jal Shakti

Mekedatu project and the latest order

The Cauvery Water Management Authority endorsed an order directing Karnataka to release 3,500 Cusecs (around 4.5 TMC ft) of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu. Tamil Nadu has opposed Karnataka's proposed Mekedatu Balancing Reservoir Project, which aims to supply drinking water to Bengaluru and generate approximately 400 MW of power. Tamil Nadu raised objections to the project in 2018 and approached the Supreme Court.

- CWMA endorsed an order: Karnataka to release 3,500 Cusecs (around 4.5 TMC ft) to Tamil Nadu
- Tamil Nadu has opposed Karnataka's proposed Mekedatu Balancing Reservoir Project
- Mekedatu aims to provide drinking water to Bengaluru city
- Mekedatu aims to generate approximately 400 MW of power
- Mekedatu is a proposed project on the Cauvery
- Tamil Nadu raised objections against the project in 2018 and approached the Supreme Court
- Tamil Nadu opposes any project in the upper riparian region without Supreme Court approval
- This stance is meant to protect water flow to Tamil Nadu

Mind-map outline

Latest order and Mekedatu

- CWMA endorsed order
 - Karnataka to release 3,500 Cusecs
 - Around 4.5 TMC ft
- Mekedatu Balancing Reservoir Project
 - Drinking water for Bengaluru
 - Approximately 400 MW power
 - Proposed project
- Tamil Nadu's stance
 - Objected in 2018
 - Approached Supreme Court
 - Opposes upper riparian projects without SC approval

Gorkhaland Issue

Historical Evolution and Gorkha Identity

The Gorkhas are people of Nepali origin, and the term is linked to the historic Gorkha Kingdom of Western Nepal. Political demands for greater autonomy trace back to the early twentieth century, and they were later voiced through a 1947 memorandum seeking Gorkhasthan and the 1980s agitation led by the Gorkha National Liberation Front. Over time, the movement increasingly articulated its objective as achieving statehood within the Indian Union.

- Gorkhas are people of Nepali origin, named after Guru Gorakhnath, a revered warrior-saint
- The term is linked to the historic Gorkha Kingdom of Western Nepal
- Prithvi Narayan Shah, a Gorkha ruler, played a central role in unification of Nepal
- 1907: Darjeeling Hillmen's Association, led by Sonam Wangyel Laden La, petitioned during Minto-Morley Reforms
- Gorkha Officers' Association and Kurseong Gorkha Library kept raising demands for greater political autonomy
- 1929: demands were presented before the Simon Commission
- 1947: undivided Communist Party of India submitted a memorandum seeking Gorkhasthan to Jawaharlal Nehru and Liaquat Ali Khan
- 1980: Gorkha National Liberation Front, led by Subhas Ghising, emerged
- The GNLF became the principal political force behind the intense Gorkhaland agitation of the 1980s
- The movement increasingly articulated its objective as achieving statehood within the Indian Union

Mind-map outline

Historical Evolution

- Origins
 - Gorkha name linked to Western Nepal kingdom
 - Guru Gorakhnath as revered warrior-saint
- Early demands
 - 1907 Darjeeling Hillmen's Association petition

- 1929 demands before Simon Commission
- Post-independence
 - 1947 Gorkhasthan memorandum
 - Undivided Communist Party of India submission
- 1980s agitation
 - GNLF led by Subhas Ghising
 - Objective: statehood within Indian Union

Major Bases of the Demand

Supporters argue that the Darjeeling Hills population has a distinct linguistic, cultural and social identity compared with the Bengali-majority plains. Concerns over identity insecurity and racial stereotyping have strengthened demands for stronger political recognition and representation. Economic concerns cover infrastructure, employment, developmental neglect and insufficient political and fiscal autonomy.

- The Darjeeling Hills population has a distinct linguistic, cultural and social identity compared with the Bengali-majority plains
- The region has a predominantly Nepali-speaking population
- Identity insecurity and racial stereotyping have contributed to demands for stronger political recognition and representation
- Proponents seek recognition of the community as an integral part of India, rather than separation from the country
- Inadequate infrastructure is a long-standing economic concern
- Limited employment opportunities and developmental neglect are raised as concerns
- Insufficient political and fiscal autonomy is a concern
- The region contributes through sectors such as Darjeeling Tea, Forestry and Tourism

Mnemonic - Economic Concerns Recall: Ideal Jobs Deserve Autonomy

I = Inadequate infrastructure; J = Limited employment opportunities; D = Developmental neglect; A = Insufficient political and fiscal autonomy

Mind-map outline

Bases of the Demand

- Ethno-linguistic identity
 - Distinct identity versus Bengali-majority plains
 - Predominantly Nepali-speaking population
 - Identity insecurity and racial stereotyping
- Economic concerns
 - Inadequate infrastructure
 - Limited employment opportunities
 - Developmental neglect
 - Insufficient political and fiscal autonomy
- Proponents' stance
 - Recognition as integral part of India
 - Not separation from India

Institutional Arrangements

Two arrangements have given the hill region a measure of autonomy. The Darjeeling Gorkha Hill Council, established in 1988, was constrained by limited legislative authority, inadequate financial autonomy and dependence on the state government. The Gorkhaland Territorial Administration, established in 2011, was a more empowered autonomous arrangement with greater administrative, executive and financial responsibilities.

- The Darjeeling Gorkha Hill Council (DGHC) was established in 1988
- The DGHC was set up following the Gorkhaland agitation of the 1980s to provide greater autonomy to the hill region
- The effectiveness of the DGHC was constrained by limited legislative authority
- The DGHC had inadequate financial autonomy and depended on the state government
- The Gorkhaland Territorial Administration (GTA) was established in 2011
- The GTA was a more empowered autonomous arrangement than the DGHC

- The GTA received greater administrative, executive and financial responsibilities than the DGHC

Mnemonic - DGHC Limitations Recall: Lazy Friends Depend

L = Limited legislative authority; F = Inadequate financial autonomy; D = Dependence on state government

Mind-map outline

Institutional Arrangements

- DGHC (1988)
 - Set up after 1980s agitation
 - Limited legislative authority
 - Inadequate financial autonomy
 - Dependence on state government
- GTA (2011)
 - More empowered autonomous arrangement
 - Greater administrative responsibilities
 - Greater executive responsibilities
 - Greater financial responsibilities

Current Process and Challenges

The Ministry of Home Affairs recently convened a Tripartite Meeting with the Government of West Bengal and Gorkha community representatives. The Union Government then constituted a committee headed by Pankaj Kumar Singh to work out modalities for a Permanent Political Solution. The challenges include opposition to territorial division, the region's strategic location, fragmented Gorkha politics and economic sustainability.

- The Ministry of Home Affairs recently convened a Tripartite Meeting with the Government of West Bengal and Gorkha community representatives
- The Union Government constituted a committee headed by Pankaj Kumar Singh
- The committee will examine the issue within the Constitutional Framework, including governance, financial assistance and development support
- The committee will also work out a roadmap for granting Scheduled Tribe status to 11 Gorkha communities
- Opposition in parts of West Bengal to territorial division reflects concerns over territorial integrity and administrative cohesion
- The Darjeeling region occupies the Siliguri Corridor (Chicken's Neck), close to Nepal, Bhutan and Bangladesh
- The Siliguri Corridor is the principal land link between mainland India and the Northeast
- Prolonged instability in the region can have wider strategic and national security implications
- Gorkha Janmukti Morcha and Gorkha National Liberation Front are among several groups, making a common position difficult
- The regional economy depends on tea, tourism and related activities, which face structural and seasonal challenges

Mnemonic - Challenges Recall: Cute Squirrels Find Eggs

C = Competing sub-national aspirations; S = Strategic importance of the region; F = Fragmented political representation; E = Economic sustainability

Mind-map outline

Current Process and Challenges

- Current process
 - MHA Tripartite Meeting
 - Committee headed by Pankaj Kumar Singh
 - ST roadmap for 11 communities
- Challenges
 - Competing sub-national aspirations
 - Strategic importance of Siliguri Corridor
 - Fragmented political representation
 - Economic sustainability

Polity & Governance

Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026

NEET-UG 2024 leak and the 2024 Act

The 2026 Amendment follows the NEET-UG 2024 paper leak controversy, in which alleged leak networks were reported in Patna (Bihar) and Hazaribagh (Jharkhand). Investigations and Supreme Court monitoring exposed organised cheating syndicates. Parliament responded by enacting the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, which the text describes as India's first dedicated central legislation on this issue.

- NEET-UG 2024 paper leak: alleged leak networks in Patna (Bihar) and Hazaribagh (Jharkhand)
- 67 candidates secured full marks, aided by disputed grace marks
- The full-marks outcome triggered nationwide protests and judicial scrutiny
- CBI investigation and Supreme Court monitoring exposed organised cheating syndicates
- Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 was enacted in response
- The Act is India's first dedicated central legislation on paper leaks, organised cheating and exam-related fraud
- Act covers exams by UPSC, SSC, Railway Recruitment Boards, National Testing Agency and Institute of Banking Personnel Selection
- Later controversy intensified demands for stronger deterrence and faster legal proceedings

Mind-map outline

NEET-UG 2024 to 2024 Act

- Leak and probe
 - Patna (Bihar) and Hazaribagh (Jharkhand)
 - CBI investigation, Supreme Court monitoring
- Controversy
 - 67 candidates with full marks
 - Disputed grace marks
 - Nationwide protests, judicial scrutiny
- Response
 - Public Examinations Act, 2024
 - First dedicated central legislation

Harsher punishments under the 2026 Amendment

The 2026 Amendment revises penalties across four categories: individual offences, service providers, organised examination crime and organised crimes. Individual offences move from 3-5 years to 5-10 years, and the service-provider ban rises from 4 years to 8 years. Organised examination crime and organised crimes also get revised minimum terms and fines.

- Individual offences: 3-5 years earlier, 5-10 years under the amendment
- Individual offences: fine up to ₹50 lakh under the amendment
- Service providers: ban raised from 4 years to 8 years
- Organised examination crime: at least 3 years and ₹1 crore fine earlier
- Organised examination crime: at least 5 years and ₹5 crore fine under the amendment
- Organised crimes: at least 7 years and ₹10 crore fine under the amendment
- The booklet table compares earlier and amended provisions for all four categories

Mnemonic - Four penalty categories: Individuals Serve Exam Orders

Individuals = Individual offences: 5-10 years, fine up to ₹50 lakh; Serve = Service providers: 8-year ban; Exam = Organised examination crime: at least 5 years, ₹5 crore fine; Orders = Organised crimes: at least 7 years, ₹10 crore fine

Mind-map outline

Harsher punishments, 2026

- Individual offences
 - 3-5 years earlier
 - 5-10 years now
 - Fine up to ₹50 lakh
- Service providers
 - 4-year ban earlier
 - 8-year ban now

- Organised examination crime
 - 3 years, ₹1 crore earlier
 - 5 years, ₹5 crore now
- Organised crimes
 - At least 7 years
 - Fine of ₹10 crore

Speedy trial: Fast-Track Courts and timelines

The amendment gives statutory backing to Fast-Track Courts for offences under the Act and sets a combined timeline for investigation and trial. Appeals before High Courts are heard by a two-judge bench and disposed of within a fixed period. Supreme Court precedents treat speedy trial as a fundamental right and recognise that no fixed time limit can be set for all criminal trials.

- Statutory backing for Fast-Track Courts to try offences under the Act
- Initial Fast-Track Courts announced in 4 High Courts where NEET-related cases are pending
- 11th Finance Commission (2000-2005) first recommended Fast Track Courts in 2000
- Combined timeline: investigation within 2 months and trial within 3 months, 5 months in all
- Appeals before High Courts heard by a 2-Judge Division Bench and disposed of within 3 months
- Aim: examination fraud cases should not remain pending for prolonged periods
- Hussainara Khatoon v. State of Bihar (1979): speedy trial recognised as a Fundamental Right under Article 21
- P. Ramachandra Rao v. State of Karnataka (2002): no fixed time limit can be prescribed for concluding criminal trials
- Fast-Track Special Courts set up in October 2019 under a Centrally Sponsored Scheme for rape and POCSO Act cases

Mnemonic - Fast-track history: Eleven-in-two-thousand, four High Courts first

Eleven-in-two-thousand = 11th Finance Commission first recommended Fast Track Courts in 2000; Four High Courts = Initial Fast-Track Courts announced in 4 High Courts for pending NEET-related cases

Mind-map outline

Speedy trial and timelines

- Fast-Track Courts
 - Statutory backing under the Act
 - Announced in 4 High Courts
 - 11th Finance Commission recommended in 2000
- Timelines
 - Investigation: 2 months
 - Trial: 3 months
 - Combined: 5 months
- Appeals
 - Heard by 2-Judge Division Bench
 - Disposed within 3 months
- Precedents
 - Hussainara Khatoon, 1979
 - P. Ramachandra Rao, 2002

Special Task Force and high-powered task force

The Union Government is empowered to set up a Special Task Force for investigating offences under the Act, which is particularly relevant to inter-state paper-leak networks. The government has also constituted a high-powered task force under Nandan Nilekani's chairmanship to drive strategic policy reforms.

- Union Government empowered to establish a Special Task Force for investigating offences under the Act
- The Special Task Force is particularly relevant to inter-state paper-leak networks and organised criminal syndicates
- High-powered Task Force constituted under Nandan Nilekani's chairmanship
- Nandan Nilekani is Co-Founder of Infosys
- Nandan Nilekani is Founding Chairman of the Unique Identification Authority of India

- Mandate of the task force: drive strategic policy reforms

Mind-map outline

Enforcement and reform task forces

- Special Task Force
 - Set up by Union Government
 - Relevant to inter-state paper-leak networks
- High-powered task force
 - Chaired by Nandan Nilekani
 - Mandate: strategic policy reforms
 - Nilekani: Infosys co-founder

Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026

Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 and the 2026 Bill

The 1971 Act makes insult to the National Flag and Constitution, and preventing the singing of the National Anthem, punishable offences. A Bill proposes to bring Vande Mataram under similar statutory protection. The Bill proposes imprisonment up to 3 years, fine or both for intentionally insulting the song.

- Section 2 prohibits intentional insult to or disrespect for the National Flag and Constitution.
- Examples under Section 2 include burning, defacing, desecrating or showing disrespect.
- Section 3 prohibits intentionally preventing the singing of the National Anthem.
- Section 3 also prohibits causing disturbance to an assembly during its singing.
- Sections 2 and 3 each carry up to 3 years' imprisonment, fine or both.
- Section 3A was inserted through the 2003 Amendment.
- Section 3A prescribes a minimum 1 year imprisonment for second and subsequent convictions under Sections 2 or 3.
- The Bill seeks to extend statutory protection to Vande Mataram, similar to that for the National Anthem.
- Under the Bill, intentionally insulting Vande Mataram would be punishable.
- Proposed Bill punishment: imprisonment up to 3 years, fine or both.

Mind-map outline

1971 Act and 2026 Bill

- Section 2: Flag and Constitution
 - Insult, burning, defacing, desecration
 - Up to 3 years, fine or both
- Section 3: National Anthem
 - Preventing singing is an offence
 - Disturbing an assembly during singing
- Section 3A: repeat offences
 - Inserted through 2003 Amendment
 - Minimum 1 year for 2nd and later convictions
- 2026 Bill
 - Extends protection to Vande Mataram
 - Proposed: up to 3 years, fine or both

Vande Mataram: origin and early history

Vande Mataram was written by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay as a patriotic response to British promotion of 'God Save the King/Queen'. It was written on 7 November 1875 in the magazine Bangadarshan and published in the novel Anandamath in 1882. It became a rallying cry of the Swadeshi Movement after the Partition of Bengal in 1905.

- Author: Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay.
- Composed as a patriotic response to British promotion of 'God Save the King/Queen'.
- Written on 7 November 1875 in the magazine Bangadarshan.
- Published in 1882 in the Bengali novel Anandamath.
- Structure: 6 stanzas; first two in Sanskrit, last four in Bengali.
- Rabindranath Tagore sang it at the 1896 INC Session in Calcutta.

- Became the customary opening song at the Varanasi Congress Session (1905), sung by Sarala Devi Chaudhurani.
- First public use: 7 August 1905 at Town Hall, Calcutta.
- Became the rallying cry of the Swadeshi Movement after the Partition of Bengal (1905).
- In 1907, Bhikaji Cama unfurled an Indian flag at Stuttgart with the song inscribed.

Mnemonic - Vande Mataram dates: 75 writes, 82 binds, 05 rallies

75 = Written on 7 November 1875 in Bangadarshan; 82 = Published in the novel Anandamath in 1882; 05 = Rallying cry of the Swadeshi Movement after the Partition of Bengal, 1905

Mind-map outline

Vande Mataram: origin and history

- Origin
 - Author: Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay
 - Response to 'God Save the King/Queen'
- Publication
 - Written 7 Nov 1875, Bangadarshan
 - Published in Anandamath, 1882
- Structure and theme
 - Six stanzas: two Sanskrit, four Bengali
 - Praise of Mother India via Goddess Durga
- Early public use
 - Varanasi Congress 1905: opening song
 - First public use: 7 Aug 1905, Calcutta
 - Stuttgart flag, 1907
- Swadeshi link
 - Partition of Bengal, 1905
 - Rallying cry of Swadeshi Movement

National Song vs National Anthem and constitutional status

Dr. Rajendra Prasad declared Vande Mataram the National Song of India on 24 January 1950, with only its first two stanzas officially recognised. Jana Gana Mana was adopted as the National Anthem the same day, with the entire anthem officially recognised, and is already protected under the 1971 Act. The Constitution does not explicitly recognise a National Song.

- 24 January 1950: Dr. Rajendra Prasad declared Vande Mataram the National Song of India.
- Vande Mataram is to be honoured equally with the National Anthem.
- Only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram have official recognition.
- 1937 Congress Working Committee decision: only the first two stanzas to be used for national gatherings.
- Jana Gana Mana was adopted as the National Anthem on 24 January 1950, with the entire anthem officially recognised.
- Jana Gana Mana is already protected under the 1971 Act.
- The Constitution does not explicitly recognise a National Song.
- Article 51A(a): Fundamental Duties require citizens to respect the National Flag and National Anthem.
- Parliamentary protocol: sessions open with the National Anthem and close (sine die) with Vande Mataram.

Mnemonic - Official recognition of the two songs: Two for Vande, whole for Jana

Two = Only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram are officially recognised; Whole = The entire Jana Gana Mana is officially recognised

Mind-map outline

National Song vs National Anthem

- Vande Mataram (National Song)
 - Recognised 24 Jan 1950
 - Only first two stanzas official
 - Proposed for 1971 Act protection
- Jana Gana Mana (National Anthem)
 - Adopted 24 Jan 1950
 - Entire anthem officially recognised
 - Already protected under 1971 Act

- Constitutional position
 - Constitution does not explicitly recognise a National Song
 - Article 51A(a): respect Flag and Anthem

Tribunals Reforms Bill 2026

Tribunals vs Ordinary Courts

Ordinary courts and administrative tribunals differ mainly in who controls the tenure and service conditions of their members. Civil courts have judicial authority over civil suits, while tribunals are created by statute to hear special cases defined by statutes. Impartiality is a crucial requirement for judges in a court of law.

- Civil courts have judicial authority over suits of a civil nature, unless barred by law.
- Judges in ordinary courts are independent regarding tenure, terms and conditions of service.
- Administrative Tribunal members' tenure and conditions are entirely controlled by the Executive (Government).
- The presiding officer of a court is required to be trained in law.
- A tribunal President or member may not be legally trained but may be an expert in administrative matters.
- An Administrative Tribunal is an agency created by Statute and derives its powers from the State.
- Tribunals have power to try special cases defined by Statutes.
- An Administrative Tribunal may be a party to a dispute it decides.
- Impartiality is a crucial requirement for judges in a court of law.

Mind-map outline

Courts vs Tribunals

- Ordinary courts
 - Judges independent in tenure
 - Presiding officer trained in law
 - Impartiality is crucial
- Administrative tribunals
 - Created by statute
 - Members' tenure controlled by Executive
 - Members may be experts, not lawyers
 - May be party to a dispute it decides

Constitutional Framework and History

Part XIV-A, inserted by the 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act 1976, contains Articles 323A and 323B, which empower Parliament and State Legislatures to set up tribunals. In *L. Chandra Kumar vs Union of India* (1997), the Supreme Court held that judicial review is part of the Basic Structure. Tribunal decisions remain subject to scrutiny by the concerned High Court.

- Part XIV-A was inserted by the 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1976.
- Part XIV-A contains Articles 323A and 323B.
- Article 323A: Parliament alone can establish Administrative Tribunals.
- Article 323B: Parliament or State Legislatures can establish tribunals for specified matters.
- *L. Chandra Kumar vs Union of India* (1997): judicial review under Articles 226/227 and Article 32 is part of the Basic Structure.
- Tribunals aim to adjudicate specialised disputes and reduce the workload of constitutional courts.
- Tribunals operate in areas such as taxation, company law, environment, telecommunications, armed forces and administrative matters.
- Tribunal decisions remain subject to scrutiny by the concerned High Court.
- The Income Tax Appellate Tribunal, established in 1941, was the first tribunal in India.
- The First Administrative Reforms Commission recommended Civil Services Tribunals at national and state levels.

Mnemonic - Articles 323A and 323B: Alone for A, Choice for B

A (Article 323A) = Parliament alone can establish Administrative Tribunals; B (Article 323B) = Parliament or State Legislatures can establish tribunals for specified matters

Mind-map outline

Constitutional Framework

- Part XIV-A (42nd Amendment, 1976)
 - Article 323A: Parliament alone
 - Article 323B: Parliament or State legislatures
- L. Chandra Kumar (1997)
 - Judicial review is Basic Structure
- Tribunal decisions
 - Subject to High Court scrutiny

Tribunals Reforms Bill 2026 and the National Tribunals Commission

The Lok Sabha has passed the Tribunals Reforms Bill 2026, which seeks to repeal the Tribunals Reforms Act 2021 and re-enact provisions that were struck down. The Bill proposes a National Tribunals Commission that gives tribunals a common institutional framework for selection, performance review, discipline and data. The Central Government must complete appointments within three months of receiving a recommendation.

- The Lok Sabha has passed the Tribunals Reforms Bill 2026.
- The Bill seeks to repeal the Tribunals Reforms Act, 2021.
- The Bill re-enacts provisions of the 2021 Act that were struck down.
- The National Tribunals Commission provides a Common Institutional Framework for Tribunals.
- NTC functions: selection of chairpersons and members, performance review, oversight of complaints and disciplinary inquiries, administrative supervision, and a National Tribunals Data Grid.
- NTC composition: a Chairperson (SC Judge or HC Chief Justice), 2 Judicial Members and 2 Technical Members.
- Technical Members must have at least 25 years of relevant experience.
- Chairpersons are capped at 70 years and Members at 67, with a maximum five-year term, whichever is earlier.
- The framework covers 16 Tribunals and Authorities.
- The Central Government must complete the appointment process within 3 months of receiving a recommendation.
- The Supreme Court has repeatedly scrutinised provisions giving the Executive excessive control over tribunals, including in *Madras Bar Association v. Union of India* (2010-2025).

Mnemonic - NTC composition: One Chair, Two Judges, Two Techs

One Chair = One Chairperson, a Supreme Court Judge or High Court Chief Justice; Two Judges = Two Judicial Members, Chief Justices or Judges of a High Court; Two Techs = Two Technical Members with at least 25 years of relevant experience

Mind-map outline

Bill and NTC

- Bill features
 - Repeals Tribunals Reforms Act 2021
 - Re-enacts struck-down provisions
 - Follows SC directions on independence
- NTC functions
 - Selects chairpersons and members
 - Reviews member performance
 - Oversees complaints and inquiries
 - Maintains national data grid
- Composition and tenure
 - Chair: SC judge or HC Chief Justice
 - 2 judicial and 2 technical members
 - Caps: Chair 70, Members 67
 - Maximum five-year term

National Green Tribunal

The National Green Tribunal is a statutory body set up in 2010 under the National Green Tribunal Act, with the objective of giving relief and compensation for environmental damage. It is guided by principles of natural justice and is not bound by the Code of Civil Procedure, and its decisions can be executed as a decree of a civil court. Appeals can be filed in the Supreme Court within 90 days.

- The NGT is a statutory body established in 2010 under the National Green Tribunal Act (2010).
- Objective: relief and compensation for environmental damage, polluter pays principle, and sustainable development.
- India is the 3rd country after Australia and New Zealand to set up a specialised environmental tribunal.
- The Chairperson is a retired Supreme Court judge or High Court Chief Justice, appointed by the Central Government in consultation with the Chief Justice of India.
- Principal place of sitting is New Delhi, with regional benches at Kolkata, Bhopal, Pune and Chennai.
- The NGT is mandated to dispose of appeals within 6 months of their filing.
- Appeals can be filed in the Supreme Court within 90 days.
- The NGT is guided by principles of natural justice and is not bound by the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908.
- The NGT excludes the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972 and the Forest Rights Act, 2006 from its jurisdiction.
- NGT decisions are executable as a decree of a civil court.

Mnemonic - NGT objective: PRS: Pay, Relieve, Sustain

P = Polluter pays principle; R = Relief and compensation for environmental damage; S = Sustainable development

Mind-map outline

National Green Tribunal

- Objective
 - Relief and compensation
 - Polluter pays
 - Sustainable development
- Set-up
 - Statutory body, 2010
 - Principal seat: New Delhi
 - Regional benches: Kolkata, Bhopal, Pune, Chennai
- Procedure
 - Not bound by CPC
 - Appeals disposed within 6 months
 - SC appeal within 90 days

Samudra Manthan Scheme

Scheme Overview and Need

The Cabinet approved the Samudra Manthan Scheme, a National Offshore Exploration Scheme to unlock India's offshore hydrocarbon potential. It is a Central Sector Scheme under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, focused on deepwater, ultra-deepwater and frontier offshore exploration. The case for it rests on high risks, long gestation periods and the natural decline of existing fields.

- Cabinet approved Samudra Manthan, a National Offshore Exploration Scheme.
- The scheme aims to unlock India's offshore hydrocarbon potential.
- It is a Central Sector Scheme under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.
- Focus is on deepwater, ultra-deepwater and frontier offshore hydrocarbon exploration.
- Offshore exploration involves high financial and technological risks.
- Offshore projects have long gestation periods of around 5-10 years.
- A deepwater exploratory well can cost approximately \$125-150 million.
- Existing oil and gas fields face natural production declines of around 6-7% annually.
- Implementation period runs up to FY 2030-31.

Mind-map outline

Scheme overview and need

- Scheme identity
 - Central Sector Scheme
 - Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas
- Why it is needed
 - High financial and technological risks
 - Gestation of around 5-10 years
 - Existing fields decline 6-7% a year
- Cost and timeline
 - Deepwater well about \$125-150 million
 - Implementation up to FY 2030-31

Key Components and Targets

The scheme works through five components: seismic exploration, exploratory drilling, common infrastructure, manufacturing and services, and technology and capacity building. It sets production targets to add reserves, raise annual domestic output and expand the resource base. Priority is given to frontier and prospective offshore basins.

- Seismic exploration covers acquisition, processing and interpretation of seismic data.
- Seismic work is used to identify prospective offshore hydrocarbon resources.
- Exploratory drilling is accelerated in deepwater, ultra-deepwater and frontier offshore basins.
- Common infrastructure means shared offshore production and evacuation infrastructure.
- Common infrastructure aims to reduce costs and improve project viability.
- Manufacturing and services: an integrated oil and gas manufacturing and services zone.
- Technology and capacity building covers digital programme management, technology adoption, skill development, stakeholder engagement and international cooperation.
- Target: add over 600 MMTOE of reserves.
- Target: annual domestic oil and gas production from around 62 MMTOE to 80 MMTOE.
- Target: expand resource base from around 1.6 billion to 2.2 billion tonnes of oil equivalent.
- Priority basins include Krishna-Godavari, Cauvery, Mahanadi and the Andaman region.

Mind-map outline

Components and targets

- Seismic exploration
 - Acquire, process, interpret seismic data
- Exploratory drilling
 - Deepwater, ultra-deepwater, frontier basins
- Common infrastructure
 - Shared production and evacuation facilities
- Manufacturing and services
 - Integrated oil and gas zone
- Technology and capacity
 - Digital management, skills, cooperation
- Priority basins
 - Krishna-Godavari, Cauvery, Mahanadi
 - Andaman region

Financial Outlay and Risk-Sharing

The scheme has a total outlay of 84,084 crore, with separate allocations for exploratory wells, seismic data, infrastructure hubs and manufacturing zones. Government supports up to 50% of eligible drilling costs under a risk-sharing mechanism. This is designed to attract private investment into technically difficult offshore projects.

- Total outlay of the scheme is 84,084 crore.
- The scheme is a Central Sector Scheme.
- The allocation includes 60 deepwater exploratory wells.
- Common Offshore Infrastructure Hubs receive 10,000 crore.
- Oil and Gas Manufacturing and Services Zones receive 2,000 crore.
- Risk-sharing: government supports up to 50% of eligible drilling costs.

- Risk-sharing is meant to reduce the financial risk of offshore exploration.
- Risk-sharing aims to encourage private and sustained investment.

Mnemonic - Ten, two and half: Ten hubs, two zones, half the risk

Ten = 10,000 crore for Common Offshore Infrastructure Hubs; Two = 2,000 crore for Oil and Gas Manufacturing and Services Zones; Half = Government supports up to 50% of eligible drilling costs

Mind-map outline

Outlay and risk-sharing

- Total outlay
 - 84,084 crore in total
- Allocations
 - Common hubs: 10,000 crore
 - Oil and gas zones: 2,000 crore
 - 60 deepwater exploratory wells
- Risk-sharing
 - Govt supports up to 50% eligible costs
 - Attracts private investment

Significance for India

The scheme matters for energy security, because greater domestic production can reduce imports of crude oil and gas. Risk-sharing can make difficult offshore projects attractive to private investors. Indigenous technology and large-scale employment are also expected benefits.

- Greater domestic production can reduce India's dependence on imported crude oil and gas.
- Government risk-sharing can make technically difficult offshore projects attractive to private investors.
- Developing indigenous offshore technologies, equipment and services can reduce dependence on foreign capabilities.
- The scheme supports the Atmanirbhar Bharat goal.
- Large-scale exploration and associated infrastructure can generate skilled and supporting employment.

Mind-map outline

Significance for India

- Energy security
 - Less dependence on imported crude and gas
- Private investment
 - Risk-sharing makes hard projects attractive
- Atmanirbhar Bharat
 - Indigenous offshore technology and equipment
- Employment
 - Skilled and supporting jobs

Deep Ocean Mission and Matsya6000

The Deep Ocean Mission, run by the Ministry of Earth Sciences, includes the Samudrayaan mission to explore the ocean bed. Samudrayaan is a crewed expedition to 6,000 metres in the central Indian Ocean, using the Matsya6000 submersible. This programme is distinct from the Samudra Manthan Scheme.

- The Deep Ocean Mission (DOM) is spearheaded by the Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES).
- DOM was approved in 2021 with a budget of Rs 4,077 crore over five years.
- Samudrayaan is a key component of DOM and aims to explore the ocean bed.
- Samudrayaan was launched in 2021 as India's flagship deep ocean mission.
- It involves a crewed expedition to reach depths of 6,000 metres in the central Indian Ocean.
- Matsya6000 is India's premier human submersible for deep-sea exploration.
- Matsya6000 accommodates three aquanauts.
- Operating endurance is 12 hours, expandable up to 96 hours in emergencies.
- Matsya6000 is constructed from titanium alloy.
- It travels at about 5.5 km/hr using underwater thrusters.

Mnemonic - Matsya's numbers: Three aquanauts, twelve hours, six thousand metres
Three = Aquanauts Matsya6000 accommodates; Twelve = Operating endurance in hours (up to 96 in emergencies); Six thousand = Depth in metres of the crewed Samudrayaan expedition

Mind-map outline

Deep ocean context

- Deep Ocean Mission
 - Ministry of Earth Sciences
 - Approved 2021, Rs 4,077 crore over five years
- Samudrayaan
 - Crewed expedition to 6,000 metres
 - Central Indian Ocean
- Matsya6000
 - Three aquanauts
 - Endurance 12 hours, up to 96 in emergencies
 - Built from titanium alloy
 - Speed about 5.5 km/hr

Summits, Reports, Indices

Sarnath: India's 45th UNESCO World Heritage Site

Inscription and India's World Heritage status

Sarnath was inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List at the 48th session of the World Heritage Committee, held in Busan, Republic of Korea. With this inscription India has 45 World Heritage Sites, ranking 6th globally and 2nd in the Asia-Pacific region. Of these sites, 37 are cultural, 7 are natural and 1 is mixed.

- Inscribed during the 48th session of the World Heritage Committee in Busan (Republic of Korea)
- With Sarnath, India now has 45 UNESCO World Heritage Sites
- India ranks 6th globally and 2nd in the Asia-Pacific region
- India's sites: 37 Cultural, 7 Natural, 1 Mixed
- Khangchendzonga National Park (Sikkim) is India's mixed heritage site
- 1983 inscriptions: Taj Mahal, Agra Fort, Ajanta and Ellora Caves
- Dholavira (Gujarat) is the only Indus Valley Civilization site from India on the list
- India hosted the 46th Annual Session at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi
- India served as a Committee Member for the 2021-2025 term

Mind-map outline

India's World Heritage Sites

- Total 45 sites
 - 37 Cultural
 - 7 Natural
 - 1 Mixed
- Ranking
 - 6th globally
 - 2nd in Asia-Pacific
- Notable sites
 - Khangchendzonga (mixed, Sikkim)
 - Dholavira: only IVC site
 - 1983: Taj Mahal, Agra Fort
- Committee role
 - Member for 2021-2025
 - ASI: nodal agency

Sarnath's sites and the first sermon

Sarnath is where Gautama Buddha gave his first sermon after attaining enlightenment at Bodhgaya, an event known as Dharmachakra Pravartana. The site has ancient names including Rishipatana, Ishipatana and Mrigadava. Its archaeological features include several stupas, a vihara and the Ashokan Pillar, each associated with a particular event or ruler.

- Ancient names: Rishipatana, Ishipatana and Mrigadava (Deer Park)

- Buddha gave his first sermon at Sarnath after enlightenment at Bodhgaya
- The first sermon is known as Dharmachakra Pravartana (Turning of the Wheel of the Law)
- The sermon marks the beginning of the Buddhist Sangha
- Chaukhandi Stupa: meeting of Buddha and his first five disciples
- Dhamekh Stupa: marks the site of Buddha's first sermon
- Dharmarajika Stupa: traditionally associated with Emperor Ashoka and Buddha's relics
- Mulagandhakuti Vihara: Buddha's rainy-season retreat at Sarnath
- Ashokan Pillar: erected during Ashoka's reign; its Lion Capital is India's National Emblem
- Sarnath is one of 4 principal Buddhist pilgrimage sites (with Lumbini, Bodhgaya, Kushinagar)

Mind-map outline

Sarnath's sites and first sermon

- First sermon
 - After enlightenment at Bodhgaya
 - Dharmachakra Pravartana
 - Marks beginning of Sangha
- Stupas and pillar
 - Chaukhandi: first five disciples
 - Dhamekh: first sermon site
 - Dharmarajika: Ashoka and relics
 - Ashokan Pillar: Lion Capital
- Other structure
 - Mulagandhakuti: rainy-season retreat
- Ancient names
 - Rishipatana, Ishipatana, Mrigadava

UNESCO, the Convention and the recognition process

The World Heritage List is maintained by the World Heritage Programme and administered by the UNESCO World Heritage Committee. The Convention concerning Protection of World Cultural and Natural Heritage was adopted in 1972, took effect in 1975, and was ratified by India in 1977. In India the Archaeological Survey of India is the nodal agency, while ICOMOS and IUCN carry out the assessment before the Committee takes the final decision.

- UNESCO was founded in 1945; its headquarters are in Paris, France
- UNESCO stands for United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization
- The World Heritage List is maintained by the World Heritage Programme
- The list is administered by the UNESCO World Heritage Committee
- The World Heritage Convention was adopted by UNESCO in 1972
- The Convention formally took effect in 1975
- India ratified the Convention in 1977
- Nodal agency in India: Archaeological Survey of India
- Assessment is done by ICOMOS and IUCN; final decision by the World Heritage Committee

Mind-map outline

UNESCO recognition process

- Convention
 - Adopted 1972
 - Took effect 1975
 - India ratified 1977
- Evaluation
 - ICOMOS
 - IUCN
- Decision
 - World Heritage Committee
- Bodies
 - UNESCO: founded 1945
 - UNESCO HQ: Paris
 - ASI: India's nodal agency

Gautama Buddha and Buddhism

Gautama Buddha was born as Siddhartha in 563 BC at Lumbini, near Kapilavastu, and died at Kushinagara in 487 BC. He taught the Middle Path, the Four Noble Truths and the 8-Fold Path, and he called himself Tathagata. After his death his teachings were divided into three Pitakas at the First Buddhist Council.

- Born as Siddhartha in 563 BC at Lumbini (Nepal), near Kapilavastu
- Father was an elected ruler of Kapilavastu and headed the Shakya republican clan
- Mother was a princess from the Koshalan dynasty
- Death (Mahaparinirvana) at Kushinagara in 487 BC
- Referred to himself as Tathagata (one who has thus come or gone)
- Buddhism based on his teachings, developed in the 6th century BC
- Buddhism rejects the authority of the Vedas and the concept of soul (atman)
- Middle Path (Madhyam Marg): avoid the extremes
- Four Noble Truths: suffering, its cause, its ending, and the path to ending it
- 8-Fold Path: right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, mindfulness, effort, concentration

Mnemonic - The 8-Fold Path: Very Intelligent Students Always Learn Many Exciting Concepts

V = Right view; I = Right intention; S = Right speech; A = Right action; L = Right livelihood; M = Right mindfulness; E = Right effort; C = Right concentration

Mnemonic - The three Pitakas: Sun Verifies Analysis

S = Sutta Pitaka: main teachings of Buddha; V = Vinaya Pitaka: rules of conduct for monks and nuns; A = Abhidhamma Pitaka: philosophical analysis

Mind-map outline

Buddha and Buddhism

- Life
 - Siddhartha, 563 BC
 - Birthplace: Lumbini, Nepal
 - Death at Kushinagara, 487 BC
- Teachings
 - Middle Path
 - 4 Noble Truths
 - 8-Fold Path
- Texts
 - Sutta Pitaka
 - Vinaya Pitaka
 - Abhidhamma Pitaka
- Councils
 - 3 Pitakas at First Council
 - Mahakashyapa chaired First Council

UNCCD COP17 and Land Restoration

UNCCD and COP17 at a Glance

The UNCCD is the principal legally binding framework on desertification, land degradation and drought, and it is one of three Rio Conventions. Its core objective is sustainable land management and achieving Land Degradation Neutrality by 2030. COP17 concluded in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, and Egypt will host COP 18 in 2028.

- Adopted on 17 June 1994, observed as World Day to Combat Desertification
- Came into force in December 1996
- Principal legally binding framework dealing specifically with desertification, land degradation and drought
- Core objective: promote sustainable land management and achieve Land Degradation Neutrality by 2030
- LDN: quantity and quality of land resources remain stable or improve to support ecosystem functions and services
- LDN is linked with SDG Target 15.3
- Conference of the Parties (COP) is the principal decision-making body of UNCCD

- Membership: 197 Parties (196 countries plus the European Union)
- COP17 concluded in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, under the theme 'Restoring Land. Restoring Hope.'
- Egypt will host UNCCD COP 18 in Sharm El-Sheikh in 2028

Mind-map outline

UNCCD basics

- Principal framework on land issues
 - Desertification, land degradation, drought
- Land Degradation Neutrality
 - Land resources stable or improved
 - Linked with SDG Target 15.3
- Rio Conventions
 - UNFCCC, CBD and UNCCD

Drought: Index, Facility and Treaty

Drought was a major focus at COP17, which saw a new Drought Resilience Index introduced to assess national preparedness. The Drought Resilience Investment Facility, launched by UNCCD and Luxembourg, uses public finance to attract private and institutional capital. Countries could not agree on a legally binding global drought agreement, and drought gets a standalone agenda item from COP 18 onwards.

- Drought Resilience Index: a comprehensive technical instrument for assessing national preparedness against drought
- The index combines AI-based analytics, vulnerability assessment and risk mapping
- Aim: shift drought management from post-disaster relief to anticipatory planning and resilience-building
- Drought Resilience Investment Facility (DRIF) was launched by UNCCD and Luxembourg
- DRIF uses public finance to de-risk investments and attract private and institutional capital
- DRIF focuses on drought resilience, water security, climate-resilient agriculture and land restoration
- Around USD 1.3 billion in new and pipeline funding was announced for land restoration and drought resilience in vulnerable countries
- Countries could not reach consensus on a legally binding global agreement on drought
- From COP 18 onwards, drought will receive a standalone agenda item

Mnemonic - Drought Resilience Index components: Always Verify Risk

A = AI-based analytics; V = Vulnerability assessment; R = Risk mapping

Mind-map outline

Drought at COP17

- Drought Resilience Index
 - AI-based analytics
 - Vulnerability assessment
 - Risk mapping
 - Anticipatory planning
- DRIF
 - Launched by UNCCD and Luxembourg
 - Public finance de-risks investments
 - Attracts private capital
- Finance
 - About USD 1.3 billion new and pipeline
- Global drought treaty
 - No consensus on binding deal
 - Standalone agenda item from COP 18

Global Partnerships and Finance

The Riyadh Global Drought Resilience Partnership, launched at COP 16 in 2024, initially secured around USD 2.15 billion and aims to support 80 countries. The Business4Land Initiative is UNCCD's major platform for private sector involvement in sustainable land management, water management and land restoration. COP17 also promoted nature-based solutions and ecosystem restoration in national development planning.

- Riyadh Global Drought Resilience Partnership was launched during UNCCD COP 16 in Riyadh in 2024

- The partnership initially secured around USD 2.15 billion in commitments
- Its aim is to support 80 vulnerable and drought-affected countries through public and private finance
- Business4Land Initiative is UNCCD's major platform for involving the private sector
- Business4Land covers sustainable land management, water management and land restoration
- COP17 promoted greater adoption of Nature-based Solutions
- COP17 promoted Ecosystem-based Adaptation and Ecosystem Restoration in national development planning
- Land degradation affects approximately 40% of the world's land surface
- Land degradation threatens ecosystems, agriculture, water availability and economic stability

Mind-map outline

Partnerships and finance

- Riyadh Global Drought Resilience Partnership
 - Launched at COP 16, Riyadh, 2024
 - About USD 2.15 billion initial commitments
 - Aims to support 80 countries
- Business4Land Initiative
 - Private sector involvement
 - Land management, water, restoration
- Nature-based solutions
 - Ecosystem-based adaptation
 - Ecosystem restoration in planning

India's Position and National Programmes

India launched a Guide to Grasslands and Other Open Natural Ecosystems at COP17 to improve their recognition and conservation. Under the Bonn Challenge, India has brought around 21.76 million hectares of degraded and deforested land under restoration, against a broader target of 26 million hectares by 2030. Domestic programmes include the National Action Plan to Combat Desertification, the Green India Mission, Mission Amrit Sarovar and the Aravalli Green Wall Initiative.

- India is a Party to the UNCCD
- India launched the Guide to Grasslands and Other Open Natural Ecosystems (ONEs) at COP17
- The guide seeks to improve recognition and conservation of ONEs such as the Thar Desert and Banni Grasslands
- It also covers Deccan Savannas, Ravines and other open ecosystems
- Under the Bonn Challenge, India has brought around 21.76 million hectares under restoration
- This is part of India's broader target of restoring 26 million hectares by 2030
- National Action Plan to Combat Desertification was introduced in 2001 and revised in 2023
- Green India Mission is a component of the National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC) and focuses on forest restoration and carbon sequestration
- Mission Amrit Sarovar focuses on creation and rejuvenation of water bodies; Aravalli Green Wall Initiative restores degraded Aravalli areas

Mnemonic - India's Bonn Challenge figures: Twenty-one restored, twenty-six by thirty

21.76 = Million hectares restored so far under the Bonn Challenge; 26 = Million hectares target by 2030

Mind-map outline

India's position

- ONEs guide launched at COP17
 - Thar Desert, Banni Grasslands
 - Deccan Savannas, Ravines
- Bonn Challenge
 - 21.76 Mha restored so far
 - Target 26 Mha by 2030
- National programmes
 - NAP to Combat Desertification (2001, revised 2023)
 - Green India Mission (under NAPCC)
 - Mission Amrit Sarovar: water bodies
 - Aravalli Green Wall Initiative

Global Tiger Day and Tiger Conservation

Global Tiger Day and the TX2 Goal

Global Tiger Day is observed every year on 29 July and traces its origin to the 2010 St. Petersburg Tiger Summit in Russia. Thirteen Tiger Range Countries, including India, adopted the St. Petersburg Declaration. Their shared TX2 goal was to double the global wild tiger population by 2022.

- Observed annually on 29 July; the booklet credits IUCN with the observance
- Established at the 2010 St. Petersburg Tiger Summit, Russia
- 13 Tiger Range Countries, including India, adopted the St. Petersburg Declaration
- TX2 goal: double the global wild tiger population by 2022
- TX2 was chosen as the initiative's motto
- Global Tiger Recovery Programme was launched
- 2010: Global Tiger Day celebrated to bolster international tiger conservation efforts

Mind-map outline

Global Tiger Day and TX2 goal

- Observed 29 July annually
- Established at 2010 St. Petersburg summit
- 13 Tiger Range Countries incl. India
- TX2: double wild tigers by 2022
- Global Tiger Recovery Programme launched

Global Initiatives: IUCN, NTCA Eco-Tourism and IBCA

The IUCN Integrated Tiger Habitat Conservation Programme supports habitat restoration, anti-poaching measures and community-led coexistence across Asia. The NTCA Eco-Tourism Initiative provides an integrated platform for authentic safari and accommodation bookings. The International Big Cat Alliance, launched in 2023, is an India-led effort covering seven big cat species.

- IUCN programme supports habitat restoration, anti-poaching and community-led coexistence
- The IUCN programme covers Asia
- NTCA Eco-Tourism Initiative is an integrated platform for bookings
- The platform covers authentic safari and accommodation bookings
- International Big Cat Alliance was launched in 2023
- The International Big Cat Alliance is India-led
- It covers seven big cat species: Tiger, Lion, Leopard, Snow Leopard, Cheetah, Jaguar, Puma
- 1st International Big Cat Alliance Summit was scheduled for June 2026 in New Delhi and is marked postponed

Mnemonic - Seven big cat species of the IBCA: Tigers Like Lazy Snowy Cats, Just Playing

T = Tiger; L = Lion; L = Leopard; S = Snow Leopard; C = Cheetah; J = Jaguar; P = Puma

Mind-map outline

Global initiatives

- IUCN Integrated Tiger Habitat programme
 - Habitat restoration
 - Anti-poaching measures
 - Community-led coexistence across Asia
- NTCA Eco-Tourism Initiative
 - Integrated booking platform
 - Safari and accommodation bookings
- International Big Cat Alliance (2023)
 - India-led
 - Covers 7 big cat species
 - 1st summit (June 2026, New Delhi) postponed

Indian Institutions and Conservation Milestones

The National Board for Wild Life is a statutory board under the Wild Life Protection Act, 1972, and works to promote conservation of wildlife and forests. Project Tiger, launched in 1973, is overseen by the National Tiger Conservation Authority, which conducts the tiger census along with the Wildlife Institute of India. The milestones run from the 1969 ban on export of wild cat skins to the 2023 launch of the International Big Cat Alliance.

- National Board for Wild Life is a statutory board under the Wild Life Protection Act, 1972
- Project Tiger was launched in 1973 to support preservation of tigers in India
- Project Tiger is overseen by the National Tiger Conservation Authority
- Tiger census estimates population through a 4-year census cycle
- Census is conducted by NTCA and the Wildlife Institute of India
- M-STrIPES (2010) is a software-based monitoring system for tiger reserves
- 1969: ban on export of all wild cat skins
- 1972: Wildlife Protection Act enacted
- 2006: amendment to the Wildlife (Protection) Act
- 2023: International Big Cat Alliance launched

Mind-map outline

Indian institutions

- National Board for Wild Life
 - Statutory board under WPA 1972
 - Promotes wildlife and forest conservation
- Project Tiger
 - Launched 1973
 - Overseen by NTCA
- Tiger census
 - 4-year cycle
 - Conducted by NTCA and WII
- M-STrIPES (2010)
 - Software-based monitoring
 - Intensive Protection and Ecological Status

Tiger Reserves and Tiger Population in India

India has 58 Tiger Reserves, which are specially designated protected areas under Project Tiger and cover over 2.3 per cent of India's total land. Madhya Pradesh leads with the most reserves, and Corbett has the highest tiger abundance among them. India's tiger population was 3,682 in the 2022 figure, with Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka as the top states.

- India has 58 Tiger Reserves
- Tiger Reserves are specially designated protected areas under Project Tiger
- Tiger Reserves constitute over 2.3% of India's total land
- Madhya Pradesh leads with 9 reserves, followed by Maharashtra and Karnataka
- Largest tiger reserve: Nagarjunsagar Srisailem
- Smallest tiger reserve: Bor (Maharashtra)
- Highest tiger abundance: Corbett (260), followed by Bandipur (150)
- Top states by tiger population: Madhya Pradesh (785) and Karnataka (563)
- India's tiger population was 3,682 in 2022
- Tiger Reserves are notified by State Governments and governed by NTCA; boundary changes need NTCA recommendation and National Board approval

Mind-map outline

Tiger reserves and population

- Reserves
 - 58 in India
 - Specially designated under Project Tiger
 - Cover over 2.3% of land
- Size and rank
 - Largest: Nagarjunsagar Srisailem
 - Smallest: Bor (Maharashtra)

- Tiger numbers
 - Highest abundance: Corbett (260)
 - 3,682 tigers in 2022
 - Madhya Pradesh (785); Karnataka (563)
- Changes to boundaries
 - Needs NTCA recommendation
 - Needs National Board approval

Glaw Lake becomes India's 101st Ramsar Site

Glaw Lake and India's Ramsar Network

Glaw Lake, a pristine freshwater lake in the Eastern Himalayas region of Arunachal Pradesh, became India's 101st Ramsar Site. It lies in the protected area of Kamlang Tiger Reserve and Wildlife Sanctuary.

- Glaw Lake became India's 101st Ramsar Site
- Location: Arunachal Pradesh; region: Eastern Himalayas
- Type: pristine freshwater lake
- Protected area: Kamlang Tiger Reserve and Wildlife Sanctuary
- Largest Indian Ramsar site: Sunderbans, West Bengal
- Smallest Indian Ramsar site: Vembannur Wetland Complex, Tamil Nadu
- Maximum Ramsar sites in one state: Tamil Nadu (14)
- Named Indian Ramsar sites: Chilika, Keoladeo, Harike, Loktak and Wular

Mind-map outline

Glaw Lake and India's Ramsar network

- Glaw Lake
 - Arunachal Pradesh
 - Kamlang Tiger Reserve
- Network growth
 - 26 sites (2014)
 - 101 sites (2026)
- Largest and smallest
 - Largest: Sunderbans, West Bengal
 - Smallest: Vembannur Wetland Complex, Tamil Nadu

Wetlands: Meaning and Types

A wetland is an area of land covered by water, whether salt, fresh or in between, either seasonally or permanently. Wetlands take many forms, from lakes and rivers to mangroves and coral reefs. The booklet classifies them into three segments: inland, coastal and human-made wetlands.

- Wetland: land covered by water that is salt, fresh or in between
- The water cover may be seasonal or permanent
- Includes lakes, rivers, underground aquifers and swamps
- Includes wet grasslands, peatlands, deltas and tidal flats
- Includes mangroves, coral reefs and other coastal areas
- Other forms: marshes, bogs, mudflats, ponds, billabongs, lagoons, floodplains
- Segment 1: inland wetlands
- Segment 2: coastal wetlands
- Segment 3: human-made wetlands

Mnemonic - Three wetland segments: I Can Help wetlands

I = Inland wetlands; C = Coastal wetlands; H = Human-made wetlands

Mind-map outline

Wetlands

- Meaning
 - Land covered by water
 - Salt, fresh or in between
- Forms
 - Lakes, rivers, aquifers

- Mangroves, coral reefs
- Peatlands, deltas, tidal flats
- Three segments
 - Inland
 - Coastal
 - Human-made

Ramsar Convention and Montreux Record

The Ramsar Convention, formally the Convention on Wetlands of International Importance, is an intergovernmental treaty adopted in 1971 in Ramsar, Iran, and in force from 1975. It has 172 member states, and India became a signatory on 1 February 1982. The Montreux Record, launched in 1990, lists Ramsar sites where ecological character has changed or is likely to change.

- Official name: Convention on Wetlands of International Importance
- Adopted in 1971 in Ramsar, Iran; came into force in 1975
- Members: 172 States
- India became a signatory on 1 February 1982
- World Wetlands Day: 2 February
- 2026 theme: Wetlands and Traditional Knowledge: Celebrating Cultural Heritage
- Conference of Parties (COP) meets every 3 years
- Montreux Record: launched 1990; lists sites with ecological change from technological developments, pollution or human interference
- Indian sites in Montreux Record: Keoladeo National Park (Rajasthan) and Loktak Lake (Manipur)
- Largest Ramsar site in the world: Pantanal, South America

Mnemonic - Montreux Record triggers: Think Pollution Hurts

T = Technological developments; P = Pollution; H = Other human interference

Mind-map outline

Ramsar Convention

- Origins
 - Adopted 1971, Ramsar, Iran
 - In force 1975
- World Wetlands Day
 - 2 February
 - 2026 theme: Traditional Knowledge
- Montreux Record
 - Launched 1990
 - Keoladeo National Park, Loktak Lake

Government Initiatives to Preserve Wetlands

The Amrit Dharohar Capacity Building Scheme is a joint effort of the Ministry of Tourism and MoEFCC to make optimal use of wetlands. The Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2017 provide a regulatory framework under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986. The Wetland City Accreditation Program, approved at COP 12 in 2015, recognises cities that conserve urban wetlands.

- Amrit Dharohar: joint effort of the Ministry of Tourism and MoEFCC
- Amrit Dharohar aims: optimal wetland use, biodiversity, carbon stock, eco-tourism and local income
- Amrit Dharohar focus: shift from high-volume tourism to high-value nature tourism
- National Wetland Conservation Program (1986) is implemented through State Wetland Authorities
- Wetlands Rules, 2017 notified by MoEFCC under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986
- Wetlands Rules decentralise management and provide for State or UT Wetlands Authorities
- Wetland City Accreditation: part of the Ramsar Convention, approved at COP 12 in 2015
- Accreditation requires all 6 international criteria and is valid for 6 years
- Wetland City aim: conservation and wise use of urban and peri-urban wetlands
- Nature-Culture Tourism Corridor announced between Ayodhya and Devi Patan in UP

Mnemonic - Amrit Dharohar aims: Be Cool, Earn Income

B = Biodiversity enhancement; C = Carbon stock; E = Eco-tourism opportunities; I = Income for local

communities

Mind-map outline

Government initiatives

- Amrit Dharohar scheme
 - Tourism and MoEFCC
 - High-value nature tourism
- Wetlands Rules, 2017
 - Under EP Act, 1986
 - Decentralised management
- Wetland City Accreditation
 - Approved at COP 12, 2015
 - Valid 6 years

Sports

23rd Commonwealth Games 2026 (Glasgow)

Glasgow 2026 at a glance

The 23rd Commonwealth Games were held in Glasgow, Scotland, from 23 July to 2 August 2026, bringing together 74 nations and territories. The event featured 10 sports, and its mascot Finnie was inspired by Scotland's National Animal. India's flag bearer at the Closing Ceremony was Jaismine Lamboria, and India takes over hosting rights for the 2030 Games in Ahmedabad.

- Held in Glasgow (Scotland), 23 July to 2 August 2026
- 74 nations and territories took part
- Mascot: Finnie, inspired by Scotland's National Animal
- 10 sports, 9 fewer than held at Birmingham 2022
- Sports: Athletics, Swimming, 3x3 Basketball, Track Cycling, Weightlifting, Bowls, Artistic Gymnastics, Netball, Boxing, Judo
- Scotland hosts for the 4th time (after Edinburgh 1970 and 1986, and Glasgow 2014)
- Neeraj Chopra received the Commonwealth Flag
- Jaismine Lamboria was India's flag bearer at the Closing Ceremony
- India takes over hosting rights for the 2030 Games in Ahmedabad (Gujarat)

Mnemonic - The 10 sports at Glasgow 2026: A Swift Bird Tracks Wild Bears And Nibbles Bananas Joyfully

A = Athletics; S = Swimming; B (1) = 3x3 Basketball; T = Track Cycling; W = Weightlifting; B (2) = Bowls; A (2) = Artistic Gymnastics; N = Netball; B (3) = Boxing; J = Judo

Mind-map outline

Glasgow 2026 Games

- Where and when
 - Glasgow, Scotland
 - 23 July to 2 August 2026
- Participation
 - 74 nations and territories
 - 10 sports
- Symbols and roles
 - Mascot: Finnie
 - Flag bearer: Jaismine Lamboria
 - Commonwealth Flag received: Neeraj Chopra

History and evolution of the Games

The idea of a Commonwealth-wide sporting competition can be traced to the 1911 Inter-Empire Championships in London. The first Games were held in 1930 in Canada under the name British Empire Games. The event was officially renamed Commonwealth Games in 1978, and it is organised by the Commonwealth Games Federation.

- Idea traced to the 1911 Inter-Empire Championships, London, part of the Festival of Empire during King George V's coronation celebrations
- 1st Games: 1930 at Hamilton (Canada), under the name 'British Empire Games'

- Concept of the Games credited to Canadian sportswriter Melville Marks Robinson
- Generally held once every four years
- Editions scheduled for 1942 and 1946 were not held
- Officially renamed Commonwealth Games in 1978
- Title adopted: British Empire and Commonwealth Games (1954); British Commonwealth Games (1970)
- Organised by the Commonwealth Games Federation
- Canadian athlete Gordon Smallacombe won the first gold medal in the Games' history, in Triple Jump
- India's participation since 1934; India hosted the Games in New Delhi in 2010

Mind-map outline

Evolution of the Games

- Origins
 - 1911 Inter-Empire Championships
 - Festival of Empire, London
- First Games
 - 1930, British Empire Games
 - Concept: Melville Marks Robinson
- Later changes
 - Held once every four years
 - 1942 and 1946 editions not held
 - Renamed Commonwealth Games in 1978

India's medal performance at Glasgow 2026

India won 39 medals and finished 4th on the medal tally, behind Australia, England and Canada. This was fewer than the 61 medals India won at Birmingham 2022. The booklet links the lower count to a reduced contingent and to the absence of several traditional medal-producing disciplines.

- India's total: 39 medals
- Medal tally position: 4th, behind Australia, England and Canada
- India won 61 medals at Birmingham 2022
- Boxing was India's best sport: 10 medals (7 gold, 3 silver)
- Highest-ever boxing gold tally by India at the Commonwealth Games
- Reduced contingent cited as a reason for the lower count
- Absence of traditional medal-producing disciplines, including Shooting, Wrestling, Badminton, Hockey and Table Tennis
- India did not field teams in 3x3 Basketball or Netball

Mnemonic - India's 39 medals: Thirteen Gold, Seventeen Silver, Nine Bronze: thirty-nine in all
13 = Gold medals; 17 = Silver medals; 9 = Bronze medals; 39 = Total medals

Mnemonic - Medal-producing disciplines India missed: Silly Wombats Build Huge Tents
S = Shooting; W = Wrestling; B = Badminton; H = Hockey; T = Table Tennis

Mind-map outline

India at Glasgow 2026

- Totals
 - 39 medals in all
 - Rank: 4th
 - 61 medals at Birmingham 2022
- Medal split
- Best sport
 - Boxing: 10 medals
 - 7 gold, 3 silver
 - Highest-ever boxing gold tally

Notable Indian achievements

Several Indian athletes produced historic results at Glasgow 2026. Five women boxers won gold, and Mirabai Chanu became the first Indian weightlifter to win three consecutive Commonwealth Games gold medals. Asmita Dey and Harsh Singh became India's first-ever Commonwealth Games gold medallists in judo, and Neeraj Chopra won silver in the men's javelin throw.

- Five women boxers won gold: Sakshi Chaudhary, Preeti Pawar, Jaismine Lamboria, Priya Ghanghas, Arundhati Choudhary
- Jaismine Lamboria won the Women's 57 kg Boxing gold
- Mirabai Chanu: first Indian weightlifter to win 3 consecutive CWG golds (Gold Coast 2018, Birmingham 2022, Glasgow 2026)
- Judo: Asmita Dey and Harsh Singh, India's first-ever CWG gold medallists in judo
- Neeraj Chopra won silver in the men's javelin throw
- Neeraj Chopra returned to the Games after missing Birmingham 2022

Mind-map outline

Indian achievements

- Boxing
 - 5 gold by women boxers
 - Jaismine Lamboria: 57 kg gold
- Weightlifting
 - Mirabai Chanu: 3 straight golds
- Judo
 - Asmita Dey and Harsh Singh
- Other events
 - Neeraj Chopra: javelin silver

Miscellaneous

Miscellaneous

International Affairs and Places

This group covers a three-nation defence pact in West Asia, the NATO Ankara Summit 2026, the India-Bangladesh Ganga water sharing treaty and Nauru's new indigenous name. The pact and the summit both concern collective defence, while the treaty and the renaming concern shared resources and national identity.

- Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement.
- Türkiye described the pact as a defence-oriented partnership, not an alliance aimed at a particular country.
- An armed attack on one member is to be treated as an attack on all three.
- The pact is meant to complement existing regional and international security mechanisms rather than replace them.
- The 2025 Pakistan-Saudi Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement was expanded into a trilateral framework.
- NATO Ankara Summit 2026 followed the 2025 Hague Summit.
- NATO members endorsed the Hague Defence Commitment to spend 5% of GDP on defence by 2035.
- The 1996 Ganga Water Sharing Treaty is scheduled to expire in December 2026.
- The Farakka Barrage is on the Ganga river at Murshidabad, West Bengal.
- Nauru adopted the indigenous name Republic of Naoero to strengthen cultural identity and sovereignty.

Mind-map outline

International Affairs and Places

- Mecca Joint Defence Agreement
 - Signatories: Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye
 - Attack on one is attack on all
 - Complements existing security mechanisms
- NATO Ankara Summit 2026
 - Followed the 2025 Hague Summit

- 5% of GDP on defence by 2035
- Ganga Water Sharing Treaty
 - Signed 12 December 1996
 - Expires December 2026
- Nauru as Republic of Naoero
 - Adopted indigenous name
 - Smallest island country by land area

Governance, Welfare and Digital Safety

The Indian Statistical Institute Bill 2026 would change ISI's legal status and governance, with the President of India as Visitor. The NCDC (Amendment) Bill 2026 widens direct financing for cooperatives, and PM-VBRY supports first-time employment. Meta's new teen safety rules follow a settlement with 52 State Attorneys General.

- The Indian Statistical Institute Bill 2026 was introduced in Lok Sabha and seeks to repeal the ISI Act, 1959.
- Under the Bill, the President of India would become the Visitor of the Indian Statistical Institute.
- The Visitor can review functioning, order inquiries and issue binding directions.
- The existing 33-member Council would be replaced by an 11-member Board of Governors.
- The Director would be appointed by the Board with the Visitor's prior approval and would act as chief executive officer.
- Under the Bill, central approval would be required only for the first set of regulations.
- Parliament passed the National Cooperative Development Corporation (Amendment) Bill, 2026.
- NCDC can now lend or grant funds directly to any cooperative society, subject to prescribed conditions.
- PM-VBRY completed one year, and its implementation period runs from 1 August 2025 to 31 July 2027.
- Meta plans default safety limits for teens, including a 2-hour cumulative daily limit across Instagram and Facebook.

Mnemonic - ISI Bill governance bodies: Very Big Dreams Rise

V = Visitor is the President of India; B = Board of Governors has 11 members; D = Director is appointed by the Board with the Visitor's prior approval; R = Central approval is needed only for the first set of regulations

Mind-map outline

Governance, Welfare and Digital Safety

- ISI Bill 2026
 - Repeals ISI Act, 1959
 - President becomes Visitor
 - 11-member Board of Governors
- NCDC (Amendment) Bill 2026
 - Direct loans and grants to cooperatives
 - Information sharing with RBI and banks
 - Rural location requirement removed
- PM-VBRY
 - Incentive for first-time employees
 - Employer support for 2 years
- Meta teen safety rules
 - 2-hour cumulative daily limit
 - Night mode, midnight to 6 a.m.
 - Like and reaction counts hidden

Environment, Energy and Wildlife

This group covers elephant and lion conservation, India's low rank in the Environmental Performance Index 2026, and two clean-energy schemes. The wildlife items show conservation efforts, while the index and the energy schemes show how environmental goals are being pursued.

- India observed World Elephant Day on 12 August 2026 with the theme 'Bringing the World together to help Elephants'.
- A Rs 2,500 crore regional action plan covers Karnataka, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu.

- Phase II of the Human-Elephant Conflict study covers Kerala, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Odisha and West Bengal.
- India has 33 Elephant Reserves and 150 identified elephant corridors.
- The synchronous estimation for 2021-25 put India's wild elephant population at 22,446.
- Project Lion was launched on 15 August 2020.
- The Asiatic lion population rose from 523 in 2015 to 891 in 2025.
- India ranked 176th of 177 countries in the Environmental Performance Index 2026, and Estonia topped the index.
- The Omkareshwar Floating Solar Park is on the Narmada River in Madhya Pradesh.
- GOBARdhan converts animal waste, crop residue and kitchen waste into compressed biogas and bio-slurry.

Mnemonic - EPI policy objectives: Healthy Villages Care

H = Environmental Health; V = Ecosystem Vitality; C = Climate Change

Mind-map outline

Environment, Energy and Wildlife

- Elephant conservation
 - Regional action plan: Rs 2,500 crore
 - 33 Elephant Reserves
 - Wild population estimate: 22,446
- Project Lion
 - Launched 15 August 2020
 - Lion population: 523 to 891
- Environmental Performance Index 2026
 - India ranked 176th of 177
 - Estonia topped the index
- Clean energy schemes
 - Floating solar at Omkareshwar
 - GOBARdhan: organic waste to biogas

History, Symbols and Personalities

This group covers P.C. Mahalanobis and National Statistics Day, the national flag and the role of Pingali Venkayya, and the 1946 Royal Indian Navy Mutiny. The items link science, national symbols and anti-colonial protest. Venkayya's 150th birth anniversary was marked in 2026.

- P.C. Mahalanobis is regarded as the Father of Indian Statistics.
- He founded Sankhya, India's first statistical journal, in 1933.
- He drafted India's 2nd Five-Year Plan (1956-1961), based on his four-sector model.
- India designated 29 June as National Statistics Day in 2007.
- The 2026 theme of National Statistics Day is 'Unlocking Potential of Administrative Data'.
- Pingali Venkayya was born on 2 August 1876 in Krishna, Andhra Pradesh.
- In 1921, Venkayya presented a khadi flag design to Mahatma Gandhi at the Congress session in Vijayawada.
- The white band on the flag represents peace and truth, and the Ashoka Chakra has 24 spokes.
- The Royal Indian Navy Mutiny began at HMIS Talwar in Bombay on 18 February 1946.
- Rebels in the mutiny organised under a Naval Strike Committee.

Mind-map outline

History, Symbols and Personalities

- P.C. Mahalanobis
 - Founded Sankhya in 1933
 - National Statistics Day: 29 June
- Pingali Venkayya and the flag
 - Khadi flag presented in 1921
 - Present flag adopted 22 July 1947
- Royal Indian Navy Mutiny, 1946
 - Began at HMIS Talwar, Bombay
 - Naval Strike Committee formed
 - Linked to INA trials legacy

Awards, Science and Agriculture

This group covers the Fields Medal 2026, the COSPAR Vikram Sarabhai Medal 2026 and India's new popcorn maize hybrid. The award items explain eligibility, frequency and awarding bodies, while the maize item places the crop among India's major food crops.

- The Fields Medal 2026 was awarded to Yu Deng, John Pardon, Jacob Tsimerman and Hong Wang.
- Hong Wang became the third woman to win the Fields Medal.
- The Fields Medal was established in 1936 through the efforts of John Charles Fields.
- Fields Medal recipients must be below 40 years of age at the time of the award.
- Two to four mathematicians may be honoured in each cycle, and the medal is awarded once every four years.
- The Fields Medal is awarded by the International Mathematical Union.
- Annapurni Subramaniam, Director of the Indian Institute of Astrophysics, Bengaluru, received the COSPAR Vikram Sarabhai Medal 2026.
- The COSPAR Vikram Sarabhai Medal was established in 1990 and is awarded biennially.
- The medal was conferred at the 46th Scientific Assembly in Florence, Italy.
- India's indigenous, non-GMO popcorn maize hybrid seed was launched at Musunuru, Eluru, Andhra Pradesh.

Mind-map outline

Awards, Science and Agriculture

- Fields Medal 2026
 - Awarded once every four years
 - Eligibility: under 40
 - Hong Wang: third woman winner
- COSPAR Vikram Sarabhai Medal 2026
 - Annapurni Subramaniam honoured
 - Established 1990, awarded biennially
- Popcorn maize hybrid
 - Indigenous, non-GMO seed
 - Developed with ICAR maize institute

AILET Corner

Dirac Medal 2026 and Paul Dirac

2026 Dirac Medal winners

Indian physicist Deepak Dhar won the 2026 Dirac Medal alongside three other physicists, including Bernard Derrida and Haim Sompolinsky. The recognition was for pioneering work in statistical mechanics. This subtopic covers who won and the field of their work.

- Deepak Dhar is an Indian physicist who won the 2026 Dirac Medal.
- Dhar shared the 2026 medal with three other physicists.
- Co-recipients named in the booklet include Bernard Derrida and Haim Sompolinsky.
- The 2026 medal recognised pioneering work in statistical mechanics.
- The item appears in the August 2026 Current Affairs AILET Corner.

Mnemonic - Four physicists: Four Physicists, Pioneering Statistical Mechanics

Four Physicists = Dhar and three other physicists shared the 2026 medal; Pioneering = The medal recognised pioneering work; Statistical Mechanics = The field of the recognised work

Mind-map outline

2026 Dirac Medal winners

- Deepak Dhar, Indian physicist
- Shared with three other physicists
- Derrida and Sompolinsky named
- Work: statistical mechanics

Dirac Medal: award details

The Dirac Medal is an annual award instituted in 1985 and presented by the International Centre for Theoretical Physics. It honours the legacy of Paul Dirac. Each recipient receives US\$5,000 along with the medal.

- The Dirac Medal was instituted in 1985.
- It is an annual award.
- It is presented by the International Centre for Theoretical Physics (ICTP).
- It honours the legacy of Paul Dirac.
- Each recipient receives US\$5,000 along with the medal.

Mind-map outline

Dirac Medal award

- Instituted 1985
- Annual award
- Presented by ICTP
- Each recipient: medal plus US\$5,000
- Honours Paul Dirac's legacy

Paul Dirac and the 1933 Nobel Prize

Paul Dirac is described as a renowned physicist and one of the founders of modern quantum mechanics. He received the 1933 Nobel Prize in Physics jointly with Erwin Schrödinger. The Dirac Medal honours his legacy.

- Paul Dirac is described as a renowned physicist.
- Dirac was one of the founders of modern quantum mechanics.
- Dirac received the 1933 Nobel Prize in Physics.
- The 1933 Nobel Prize was shared with Erwin Schrödinger.
- The Dirac Medal honours Dirac's legacy.

Mnemonic - Dirac and 1933: Dirac dined with Schrödinger in '33

Dirac = Paul Dirac, one of the founders of modern quantum mechanics; Schrödinger = Erwin Schrödinger, who shared the 1933 Nobel Prize in Physics with Dirac; '33 = The year of the 1933 Nobel Prize in Physics

Mind-map outline

Paul Dirac

- Renowned physicist
- Founder of modern quantum mechanics
- 1933 Nobel Prize in Physics
- Shared Nobel with Erwin Schrödinger